

CADENCE

A Faerie Tale by Robert Mac Kay

I come to write this story as a matter of sheer diction. The teller of this tale, whose name I shall presently divulge, and the circumstances by which she came to me, which I should keep secret, are of no consequence other than that of the narrative; neither may be sought out. Believers should read this account, hold it as a testimonial and for the truths contained herein. As for skeptics, I say only that this is my own invention and pure fantasy, and none of this is true...

My name is Cadence, because I was born under a new moon in the season cicadas are most about, chirping and buzzing and droning. Usually a most blessed event, a birth like mine, surrounded by nature's song...but for the new moon. Providence failed to shine on my waking hour, and this was seen by most as a bad omen. These same cited those circumstances as the cause of my denouement and subsequent isolation.

It's difficult to know just where to begin, since my story, like those of many others, has no real beginning. Events unfold from the most minute of circumstances, when suddenly a mighty oak, that is one's life, was once an acorn. You may determine the birth and death, but never catalogue growth long past. As I am, I have been witness to eight springs, have cherry hair, summer sky eyes and am this tall.[†] I don't know what I weigh, but as I am terribly hungry, it can't be much.[‡] People call us faeries, as I prefer, or if you know me, then by name. I am not a faerie. Not anymore.

Having cleared, cleaned and furnished a mouse burrow with what meager possessions I had, the place served me well since I found it. But I had higher aspirations at the time. In my sixth spring I moved from my place in the floor of the woods for a more airy dwelling. I contemplated communal living with Thistle, whose hair was creamy yellow and poofed out and spiked when cropped short, Snapper, whose two colored hair, red and yellow, reminded everyone of an old, familiar tortoise with an equal temperament, and a third faerie I did not know then. But they were three and needed space for contemplation. There was the other matter, more serious than my birth, that made me fear living with them.

There are rules for my kind, secret and unspoken. Most importantly, devotion to the Mother. It is a belief in nature and natural things. All things on Earth are not natural, only things with Cara.^Δ Even dead things have Cara. Metal has no Cara, but has a semblance of life. It is something to be used for art or habitation and is good. Machines are dark. Not evil, only dark. They have no Cara, but have life. They are cold and empty and we cannot touch them or commune. While I am fascinated and intrigued by dark machines, others fear them. Sometimes, those who study machines are ostracized for a time, those who make them are punished. I studied them, took them apart and pieced them back together. One day I would make them.

[†]Cadence stands to her full height with an outstretched arm to give this measurements. I estimate⁴ to 4.5".

[‡] Due to their diminutive size, a faeries' weight is almost entirely that of the food in their bellies.

^Δ "Essence."



Since a nest with the others would not do, I resolved to make my own. My nest would be of the same construction as a communal nest, but this provided me some difficulty.

Most of all, a nest was this: a very large sphere made of a series of members arranged in a multitude of triangles. There are about three hundred members, all about this long^o and this big around.[†] That would require many days searching for timber and pulp to tie them and days to cut and assemble everything. One faerie could take from one spring to the next to complete it. So I resorted to squeaking a box

of toothpicks and a spool of thread to the woods and the site of my construction (squeaking is a faerie term for pilfering, derived from the nasty habit of mice, usually a more noble creature). I had also found, with the thread, several lovely needles made from a clean iron. I would normally avoid such a thin, iron being such a base metal that dirtied with rust no matter how hard you tried to keep clean. Iron is no good for art and never washes clean from the body. But these needles were clean iron, steel, as you say, and I found them to be quite good. As we all know, faeries are the most skilled of designers and I had completed my nest in one summer's time. It was then, staring at my empty home, Thistle visited and told me they had found a machine in the woods by the road.

It was large, three times my height and metal, brass. It was a beautiful thing of gears and levers and springs (terms only I understood), and I had determined that it was a clock, though brutally smashed. We all thought to make some lovely things from the brass locked it its body. Four of us were investigating the works of this wondrous cre-

^o 2"

[†] 1/8"

ation when another faerie joined with amazing blue as blue hair. She told us not to touch it and warned that it was a dark thing. I laughed because

it was plainly smashed and moved for no one, and was only brass for our use.

Thistle and Morning Daisy, her nestling, climbed inside to tug on levers. I faced the blue haired and scolded her for her ignorance when Snapper pulled off a release pin.

The clock jumped to life, cutting Snapper's arm deeply as the main spring unwound, spinning gears madly, and making horrible noises. As I jumped at the

sound, being quite unaccustomed to dead things screaming, my wing struck the main gear and was drawn in. Before I could react, my poor wing was trapped and eaten between two gears, grinding their teeth. Everything happened so quickly, I could barely recall any of it. The gears tore and shredded the delicate thins of my wings and began cutting the meat and bone. My poor wing was the only thing to stop the gears. Thistle started screaming, Morning Daisy flew away and Snapper, despite her arm, tried to free me by reversing the gears. Thistle jumped to my side and held me as now I was growing quite sick and faint. I fell to my knees weeping for the pain, clutching my wing. Thistle took me by the other wing. I hold no grudge against her and certainly not Snapper for what happened next. Snapper rushed to Thistle's side, abandoning the sprung gear and took hold of my wing as well. They both pulled and tugged, panicked by my blood and ruined what was my one wing left. The trapped wing was rendered apart and the spring was spent and we tumbled to the ground. Through my tears and my blood I saw the blue haired laughing. She was laughing hysterically. And then I blacked out.

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To be continued next week...